the children in the family, companions for the ill or the elderly, besides being man, woman and child's best friend. Naturally, their families want the best for them, and spare no expense in that pursuit. A new pet owner on an average spends anything between Rs 20,000 and Rs 50,000 to get basics such as vaccinations, a bed, meds, leashes, collars and bowls. The rest depends on how deep is your love—and your pockets.

Indians have always kept pets. It's just that the need for canine/feline company just got more acute in the emotionally and socially isolating days of Covid-19. According to online data agency Statista, if Indians owned 20 million dogs in 2019, that number could well touch 31 million this year. And while dogs remained favourites as pets, cats, fish and birds found enough homes too.

"Dogs and cats have been shown to reduce loneliness and combat stress," says Samriddh Dasgupta, the Chief Marketing Officer of Heads Up For Tails (HUFT), India's largest petcare company, and a dog parent himself. "There was an increase in adoptions during the pandemic as people found themselves indoors and often alone." Noida-based art HR professional Dhriti Gurudanti, 37, found herself emotionally drained during the pandemic, but since she didn't have the space, she ended up adopting a pet virtually. "I sponsored a dog with a local NGO because I could not keep one in my apartment," she says. "I would see him on video calls and his antics always made me feel better."

Sniffing a massive opportunity, a whole industry has sprung up around petcare—from food to grooming to pet fashion to pet products to pet hotels and vacations, pet training schools, pet psychologists, pet birthdays and even pet photo-shoots. A September 2022 report by market research firm Market Decipher estimated the Indian petcare market size to be Rs 7,400 crore in 2021 and predicted it to reach Rs 21,000 crore by 2032, growing at a CAGR of 19.2 per cent. Just the pet food industry is worth a whopping Rs 4,000 crore currently, and is expected to become a Rs 10,000 crore market by 2025, according to market research firm Euromonitor.

A FULL PLATE

Such is the potential of the pet food market in India that packaged food and beverages giant Nestle India acquired the pet foods business from Purina Petcare India for Rs 123.5 crore last year, foraying into the segment for the first time. Beauty and healthcare FMCG Emami also decided to invest in petcare startup Cannis Lupus Services India last year and will now offer Ayurvedic remedies for pets under the brand name Fur Ball Story.

Even the biggest success story in the petcare industry, HUFT, had its beginning here. "Our brand was built on the back of pet food," says Dasgupta. "The diversification of our portfolio has happened only in the past few years. It was a lonely battle to sell quality pet food 14 years back—we wanted to reinvent how you pick products for your pets,



PRATHIMA PINGALI/PAWPARAZZI PET PHOTOGRAPHY

BRINGING UP BABY

Pet-lovers are prepared to spare no expense when it comes to indulging their pets. This is what it takes roughly to keep...

...A MEDIUM-SIZED LONG-HAIRED DOG

ONE-TIME COST

Microchip with lifetime Kennel Club of India registration Rs 1,500

Long-range GPS tracker: Rs 4,500

TOYS & ESSENTIALS

Kong ball: Rs 700

Non-toxic toys Rs 1,000

Bed: Rs 1,500

Leash and collar Rs 700

VET

Visit to the vet Rs 500

Annual vaccination Rs 1,000

FOOD

Dry food (regular) Rs 400 per kilo (a medium dog eats approx. 300 gm a day)

Dry food (imported) Rs 9,000 per kilo

Dog fresh food dabba service Rs 500 per day

Treats: Rs 300 per